



HIGH-TECH: HLL's modern plants produce a billion condoms annually contains a replica of a passport with strict guidelines about "entry and withdrawals" (see box). No efforts have been spared to take on the competition. The promos for the products have been done by some of the leading ad agencies, with budgets that would make cola and chocolate manufacturers sit up and take note. Last year's budget for commercial shoots alone was about Rs 10 crore, spent both on international models and locales.

The aggressive marketing is already producing results. HLL's turnover has more than doubled, from

It was not always like this. For long, the company worked in technical collaboration with Japanese condom major Okamoto, but today it is self-reliant in condom technology and has even developed a state-of-the-art machinery for electronic testing. Among all its products, only the glow condom is imported from a Malaysian company which holds the patent. The company's in-house engineers have fabricated machinery for its second plant that will soon start production from Thiruvananthapuram. A third factory in Belgaum with a capacity of 250 million pieces has been functioning since long. If combined, this would make HLL the

PASSPORT TO PLEASURE

Booklet in the Crezendo pack lists do's and don'ts

VISA TO REPUBLIC OF PLEASURE: The holder of this document is authorised to enter the State of Pleasure for the purpose of sustained enjoyment.

VISA TO TERRITORY OF RAPTURE: The wearer is authorised to proceed to Territory of Rapture after he furnishes signs of passage from initial port of entry.

ENTRY TO STATE OF ECSTASY: The user is authorised to occupy any position on state of entry.



mine, musk, rose), flavoured (strawberry, chocolate, banana—all food grade and soon to be introduced pan masala), ribbed, spotted, extra-long, extra-time and even glow condoms that supposedly light up when the lights are switched off. The company has even got some news for the millions who are victims of erectile dysfunction: sources say an "All Night" condom that will help and retain erection is on the anvil.

That HLL has pursued very non-PSU like tactics to turn itself around is obvious to anyone who switches on the idiot box. Its commercials on prime time television linger in viewers' minds. One commercial has the catch line "the only time she will love friction in a relationship" while another suggestively says "the only time she won't complain you are late". The Crezendo package

Rs 105 crore in 2000-01 to Rs 243 crore in 2005-06. Of the 250 million pieces that it sells directly to the non-government sector, 40 per cent is targeted for exports, mostly to the African continent where the scourge of AIDS is the deadliest. The company has set a target of Rs 1,000 crore by 2012, not a distant dream, considering that 70 per cent of the country's population is below 30 years of age, at least a third of whom are potential users of its products. All this has had a rub off on the company's offices and factories in Thiruvananthapuram, which look more like a private sector corporate than a staid PSU. "We have spent Rs 35 crore on refurbishing the company's premises and even our trade union offices look like plush executive floors," says Ayyappan.

world's largest condom manufacturer. What's more, the PSU is on the verge of inking a deal to take over the manufacturing facilities of India's largest condom manufacturer in the private sector.

The company is also venturing into new areas. It is setting up a chain of 13 "Life Spring" hospitals in Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh, with support from a US-based venture fund, the first three of which have already come up in Hyderabad, Kanpur and Agra. "We will have hospitals in all the 70 districts of Uttar Pradesh," said Ananth Kumar, head of HLL's hospital division. Maybe HLL should spend some of its huge profits on setting up similar hospitals in Madhya Pradesh. That perhaps will keep the likes of Vijayvargiya, the self righteous minister, from protesting too much. ■